Agents, and agents talking to agents

A goal, a loop, tools, and a reason to stop. Then one agent handing work to another.

60 min | Recorded | Class 12 of 15

12

What this session covers

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What makes something an agent
2 slides

02
Where people step in
2 slides

03
One agent handing to another
2 slides

04
Code walkthrough
4 slides

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Section 1 of 4

What makes something an agent

Most “agents” are a prompt with a marketing budget.

01

An agent has four things, and missing any one makes it something else

02

A chatbot answers; an agent keeps going until the job’s done or it can’t go on

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An agent has four things, and missing any one makes it something else

A goal	Clear the customs hold, not “help with shipping”.
A loop	Look, decide, act, look again. Class 10’s loop is the start of one.
Tools	The ways it can find things out and change things.
A reason to stop	Done, stuck, or out of steps. Without it, it runs until the bill arrives.

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A chatbot answers; an agent keeps going until the job’s done or it can’t go on

Chatbot

- One question, one answer
- A person does the next step
- Easy to check

Agent

- Plans several steps
- Calls tools between them
- Harder to check, so it needs limits

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Section 2 of 4

Where people step in

The part that decides whether this is safe.

01

Put a person at the points where a mistake leaves the building

02

Limits are what make an agent safe to leave running

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Put a person at the points where a mistake leaves the building

Before sending
Emails to customers and suppliers, customs submissions.

Before paying or changing money
Anything in PayGrid or supplier bank details.

When it’s unsure
Two options that look equally good means ask, not pick.

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Limits are what make an agent safe to leave running

- A step limit: 6 here, then it stops and hands over
- A time limit and a cost limit per task
- Read-only by default; write tools behind approval
- Every step logged, so a person can replay what happened

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Section 3 of 4

One agent handing to another

A supervisor and a specialist.

01

The customs hold from class 1's world, handled by two agents and one person

02

Agent-to-agent (A2A) is how agents on different systems talk

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The customs hold from class 1′s world, handled by two agents and one person

1

Supervisor reads the ticket: it’s a customs hold

2

Hands it to the customs worker

3

Worker looks up the shipment in Tracklane

4

Worker finds the customs runbook step

5

Worker drafts the email to the customer

6

A person reads the draft and sends it, or doesn’t

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Agent-to-agent (A2A) is how agents on different systems talk

An open protocol, the way MCP is for tools.

01 Agent card
Each agent publishes what it can do and how to reach it.

02 Tasks
One agent sends another a task and gets updates as it progresses.

03 Not MCP
MCP connects a model to tools. A2A connects one agent to another agent.

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Section 4 of 4

Code walkthrough

A supervisor, a customs worker, and a person at the end.

01

The worker looks things up and drafts, and never sends

02

The supervisor routes, and a person decides whether anything goes out

03

Where today sits on the card

04

What to do next

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The worker looks things up and drafts, and never sends

code/class12/supervisor.py

```
def customs_worker(shipment_id: str) -> str:
    """Worker: look the shipment up, find the runbook step, draft the email. Never sends it."""
    ship = get_shipment(shipment_id)
    steps = search(f"customs documents {ship.get('reason', '')}", k=2)
    notes = "\n".join(c["text"] for _, c in steps)
    return ask(f"Shipment: {ship}\nRunbook:\n{notes}\n\nDraft a short email ...", temperature=0.3)
```


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The supervisor routes, and a person decides whether anything goes out

code/class12/supervisor.py

```
for step in range(MAX_STEPS):
    decision = ask("... Reply CUSTOMS or HUMAN.\n\n" + ticket,
temperature=0).strip().upper()
    if decision == "CUSTOMS":
        shipment = next((w for w in ticket.split() if w.startswith("LOL-SH-")), None)
        if not shipment: return "handed to a person: no shipment ID in the ticket"
        draft = customs_worker(shipment.strip(".,"))
        ok = input(f"\n--- draft ---\n{draft}\n--- send? [y/N] ")
        return "sent" if ok.lower() == "y" else "held for a person"
```


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Where today sits on the card

1. A script	The steps are known and don’t change.
2. A rule	The decision is known and must be explainable line by line.
3. Classical ML	Labelled history, and the input is a table or short text.
4. A small trained model	Lots of text, images or audio, enough labels, cost per call matters.
5. An LLM with a prompt	Varied language in and out, few labels, someone checks the output.
6. An LLM plus retrieval, tools or agents	**Needs private knowledge, has to act, or takes several steps.**
7. Not yet	No ground truth, needs a guarantee, or nobody owns the result.

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What to do next

1. Run `supervisor.py` on the Nhava Sheva ticket and read the draft before saying yes.
2. Find two handwritten tickets that should never reach an agent, and say why.
3. Read the class 13 pre-reading on evaluation.

Questions after class: the course channel.

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